

vices will be operated on the same line as RRTS. “This has helped in achieving savings of ₹6,500 crore of public funds, with RRTS only losing around 12 seconds in running time,” says NCRTC’s Singh.

Private operators have been roped in for the maintenance of the rolling stock and infrastructure. Consequently, the rolling stock will be managed by French company Alstom and infrastructure, including the operation of services, by the German rail operator Deutsche Bahn. “We realised if we bring in pri-

TRAINS ON THE DELHI- MEERUT RRTS CORRIDOR WILL RUN AT 90-100 KM PER HOUR

vate operators, we can bring in a lot more efficiencies... and we can focus more on ensuring the viability of the system through land monetisation,

transit-oriented development and value financing,” states Singh.

The project, according to ISPP’s Pathak, will not only help in decongesting Delhi but will also encourage more people to move to Meerut. The logistics sector is another beneficiary. “The cost of transporting products from Meerut to Delhi will fall drastically,” he says.

Land prices on certain sections of the corridor have already risen four times in the past four years. **BT**

@manishpant22

| AUTO |

Yesterday Once More

24 |

Retro vehicles are making a comeback as EVs. Will they taste success?

BY RACHNA DHANRAJANI

► **FOR EVERY GENERATION** there are some tag lines that catch their imagination. For a host of Indians growing up in the Seventies and Eighties, “*Chal meri Luna*” and “*Hamara Bajaj*” were two such tag lines, for two iconic products—the Kinetic Luna moped and the Bajaj Chetak scooter.

Those days are gone. Now, electric vehicles (EVs) are the talk of the town. And these brands are coming back as EVs. What is it that makes companies name their new offerings after iconic products? “To have a name like Luna that is easy to remember and has a great recall value back in the market could encourage the older generation to consider the new EV options,” says brand expert Harish Bijoor, CEO of Harish Bijoor Consults, adding that the brand is targeting more than one generation.

That, of course, doesn’t guarantee success. Take the Chetak, for instance. It came back as an EV more than two years ago, but hasn’t lived up to the reputation of its predecessor. In the first five months of FY23, just 12,023 units were shipped to dealers. One possible reason for this could be its high price tag, say industry watchers. The original

Chetak was for the middle class; the electric Chetak starts at ₹1.40 lakh. The Luna might have it better: While the original was said to have been launched at ₹2,000 in 1972, the EV could be priced at around ₹50,000. “The Luna is expected to pick up because it will be affordable,” says a source.



For now, Bajaj Auto and Kinetic Engineering are focussing on production. Bajaj Auto aims to double production and sales with its new EV plant in Pune, which will have an estimated annual production capacity of 500,000 units. It also plans to introduce two new models. And Kinetic has set up a dedicated production line with an initial capacity of 5,000 units a month.

Bijoor says that when naming a product, companies have two options. The first is to name it such

that it sounds futuristic. “The second is to bring something back to the minds of people, like a retro name.”

Will it be yesterday once more for the Luna? Watch this space. **BT**

@r_dhanrajani